Even Birds Get Jet Lag

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New research shows humans are not the only species to get jet lag: some birds appear to experience it too. A study in the journal Science found that Manx shearwaters become slightly **disoriented** on long Atlantic flights, because their internal clocks fall out of sync with the sun.

Manx shearwaters are a common bird in the British Isles. They look a little like seagulls but are closely related to **albatrosses**, said Patrick Lewin, a behavioral ecologist at the University of Oxford. Shearwater couples mate for life and lay just one egg, taking turns **incubating** it: one partner sits nonstop while the other goes to sea.

For up to two weeks, the hunting partners scour the North Atlantic for fish and squid, often hundreds of miles from their nests. Once full, they bomb it back to their **colony**, Lewin said, often in just a day or so.

That raised an interesting question: do Manx shearwaters feel jet lag, or perhaps more aptly, flap lag? Lewin used 20 years of GPS tracker data from his colleagues on flights out to the Atlantic and back. Shearwaters are believed to navigate by the sun, and using the sun as a compass requires knowing the time of day: east in the morning, slightly south at midday in the northern **hemisphere**, west in the evening. With the wrong time, they would fly the wrong way.

That is what Lewin and his colleagues saw: rushing home, the birds veered slightly off course. At most, a seven-degree error took a bird about three miles out of its way on a 600-mile journey.

Alice Boyle, a biologist at the Centre for Animals on the Move at Western University in Ontario, Canada, who was not part of the study, called the paper so cool. She said almost every creature must navigate its environment, yet studies showing navigation decisions in action are rare, and wild birds travelling to remote places can teach us so much about how they do it.

Word Treasure

disoriented -- Confused about where you are or which way to go.

albatrosses -- Very large seabirds with long wings that spend most of their lives over the ocean.

incubating -- Sitting on an egg to keep it warm until it hatches.

colony -- A large group of the same kind of animal living and nesting together.

hemisphere -- One half of the Earth, such as the northern half above the equator.

Background you need

Manx shearwaters are seabirds that nest on land but spend long stretches hunting far out over the ocean.

Like many travellers, they seem to use the sun as a compass, and using the sun that way only works if you know the time of day.

Every living thing has an inner clock that keeps its body in step with day and night, and when that clock no longer matches the sun, directions based on the sun can go wrong.

That mismatch is what people call jet lag, and fast, long flights home may leave shearwaters with a version of it too.

Break it down

LEAD: New research suggests some birds, like humans, can experience jet lag.

KEY EVENT: Manx shearwaters rushing home across the Atlantic veer slightly off course.

+- WHO: Patrick Lewin and his colleagues, who studied the birds, and Alice Boyle, who was not part of the study.

+- WHAT: The birds' inner clocks fall out of sync with the sun, so their sun-based navigation goes slightly wrong.

+- EVIDENCE: 20 years of GPS tracker data, showing at most a seven-degree error on a 600-mile journey.

BACKGROUND: Shearwater pairs mate for life, lay one egg, and take turns incubating it while the other hunts far out to sea.

OPEN QUESTION: Do Manx shearwaters feel jet lag, or more aptly, flap lag?

Why it matters

The finding shows that body clocks matter far beyond humans, and studying wild birds in remote places can reveal how animals actually make navigation decisions in the real world.

Test what you remember

1. **According to the study, why do Manx shearwaters become slightly disoriented on long Atlantic flights?**
   - (A) Their inner clocks fall out of sync with the sun.
   - (B) They fly only at night.
   - (C) They are chased by albatrosses.
   - (D) They forget where their nests are.
2. **How many eggs does a shearwater couple lay?**
   - (A) None -- they do not lay eggs
   - (B) Three
   - (C) Two
   - (D) Just one
3. **What do the hunting partners look for in the North Atlantic?**
   - (A) Seaweed and shells
   - (B) Fish and squid
   - (C) Other shearwaters
   - (D) Seagulls and albatrosses
4. **What did Lewin use to study the birds' flights?**
   - (A) A weather balloon
   - (B) Photographs taken by tourists
   - (C) 20 years of GPS tracker data
   - (D) A single day of observations
5. **At most, how far out of its way did a seven-degree error take a bird on a 600-mile journey?**
   - (A) About 300 miles
   - (B) About seven miles
   - (C) About 60 miles
   - (D) About three miles
6. **What did Alice Boyle say about studies showing navigation decisions in action?**
   - (A) They are only about humans.
   - (B) They are rare.
   - (C) They happen every day.
   - (D) They prove birds never get lost.

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: D 3: B 4: C 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Patrick Lewin and his colleagues: They found that shearwaters rushing home veered slightly off course, apparently because their inner clocks fell out of sync with the sun.

2. Alice Boyle: She called the paper so cool, saying studies showing navigation decisions in action are rare and wild birds travelling to remote places can teach us a great deal about how they navigate.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):